

App Development Cost Checklist

20+ questions to answer before you ask anyone for a quote — from a studio that has shipped 22+ products to production. Tick each box; the gaps are where projects blow their budget.

1 — Define the Product

- ☐ Can you describe the core problem your app solves in one sentence?
- ☐ Have you listed the must-have features vs. the nice-to-haves?
- ☐ Do you know who your first 10 users are and what they need?
- ☐ Is there one feature that, if it works, proves the whole idea?
- ☐ Have you decided what you are NOT building in v1?

2 — Understand the Cost Drivers

- ☐ How many distinct user roles and screens does it need?
- ☐ How many third-party integrations (payments, CRM, email, APIs)?
- ☐ Does it need AI features (chat, generation, automation)?
- ☐ Real-time, offline, or heavy data requirements?
- ☐ How fast do you actually need it — and is that timeline real?

3 — Compare Your Options

- ☐ Freelancer (\$10k–\$60k): cheaper, but one person and no backup.
- ☐ Traditional agency (\$75k–\$350k+): big teams, slow, hourly creep.
- ☐ AI-assisted studio (\$997–\$30k+): fixed price, fast, you own the code.
- ☐ No-code (\$2k–\$20k): quick to start, hits a ceiling fast.
- ☐ Have you matched the option to your stage and budget — not hype?

4 — Budget for Total Cost of Ownership

- ☐ Hosting & infrastructure (\$100–\$800/mo)
- ☐ Maintenance & security patches (\$500–\$2,000/mo)
- ☐ Feature iteration after launch (\$2,000–\$8,000/mo)
- ☐ Third-party services: email, payments, AI APIs (\$150–\$1,000/mo)
- ☐ Did your quote disclose these, or just the build price?

5 — Vet Your Developer

- ☐ Can they show you shipped, live products (not just mockups)?
- ☐ Is the price a fixed quote or an open-ended hourly meter?
- ☐ Will you get full source code and own the accounts?
- ☐ Do they explain things in plain English without jargon walls?
- ☐ Is there a clear post-launch support window?

Red Flags to Walk Away From

- ☐ A quote with no fixed ceiling or milestone breakdown.
- ☐ No portfolio of real, live products.
- ☐ "We will own the code / hosting" — you should own everything.
- ☐ Vague timelines that keep sliding without explanation.
- ☐ No mention of ongoing costs until after you have signed.

Ready for a real number?

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